

1) Aether in One Line

A privacy-first resilience platform that helps students reflect, connect, and take safer next steps.

- Built for the space between "I am overwhelmed" and formal care.
- Designed to be practical, non-clinical, and trustworthy.
- Engineered as a production-ready monorepo.

Presenter notes (35 sec):

Aether is a student resilience ecosystem, not just a single app feature. The core promise is simple: help students move from uncertainty to action with dignity, while staying clear about boundaries and safety.

2) The Problem We Chose to Solve

- Students often need support before a crisis.
- Traditional pathways can feel slow, stigmatizing, or hard to navigate.
- Most digital tools force a tradeoff between personalization and privacy.

Aether's position:

Early support without surveillance. Guidance without overclaiming.

Presenter notes (45 sec):

We intentionally focused on early intervention moments: stress spikes, isolation, setbacks, and difficult transitions. Aether fills a real operational gap: what students can do right now, before issues escalate.

3) Product Surface: Five Support Modules

1. Echo Chamber: private voice/text reflection with sentiment-aware cues.
2. Resilience Pathway: guided check-ins, planning, and next-step navigation.
3. Peer-Navigator: explainable, safety-gated peer matching.
4. Privacy and Governance: transparent controls and policy boundaries.
5. Fairness Review: admin-facing oversight for matching quality and equity.

Presenter notes (55 sec):

These modules are designed to be composable. Teams can deploy the full ecosystem or phase capabilities in over time, without rewriting the whole platform.

4) What Makes Aether Better Than World Class

- Privacy-first architecture, not privacy theater.
- Human-centered AI with explicit non-clinical boundaries.
- Explainability from matching logic to support recommendations.
- Accessibility as a baseline, not a backlog item.
- Config-first modularity for campus-specific adaptation.

Presenter notes (50 sec):

"Better than world class" for us means combining technical excellence with moral clarity. We optimize not just for feature velocity, but for trust velocity: how quickly users and institutions can confidently adopt the system.

5) Implementation Architecture (Production-Ready)

flowchart LR

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A[Next.js 14 Frontend\nApp Router + TypeScript] --> B[UI Modules\nEcho | Pathway | Peer-Navigator]
B --> C[Policy + Safety Gates]
B --> D[RAG Chat API\nStatic index + retrieval]
A --> E[Node Backend\nhealth + extension APIs]
B --> F[Matching Engine\nRCSM layered pipeline]
F --> G[Fairness + Outcome Logs]
D --> G
```

- Monorepo with clear separation: frontend, backend, docs, and content.
- Quality gates: lint, typecheck, tests, coverage, production build.

Presenter notes (60 sec):

The implementation is intentionally lightweight and scalable. We avoided unnecessary infrastructure complexity while preserving strong architecture boundaries, observability surfaces, and extensibility.

6) Design Principle 1: Privacy Before Personalization

- Local-first patterns for sensitive reflection paths.
- Data minimization by default.
- Progressive disclosure for sensitive profile attributes.
- Explicit consent and visibility controls.

Result:

Higher trust, lower data exposure, safer adoption in education contexts.

Presenter notes (50 sec):

Aether does not assume "collect everything now, secure it later." We designed data boundaries as first-class product behavior, which is critical for student-facing environments.

7) Design Principle 2: Safety Before Relevance

- Hard policy gates remove unsafe matches before scoring.
- Urgent-risk triage routes to crisis pathways, not peer matching.
- Training and verification status govern navigator eligibility.
- Human moderation and governance remain in the loop.

Presenter notes (50 sec):

Many systems rank first and govern later. We do the opposite. Safety constraints are not optional penalties; they are hard constraints enforced before optimization.

8) Design Principle 3: Explainable Intelligence

Peer-Navigator matching uses a layered RCSM approach:

1. Candidate generation on eligible users.
2. Reciprocal scoring for two-way fit.
3. Constrained global optimization.
4. Stability refinement.
5. Outcome learning under safety/fairness constraints.

Presenter notes (55 sec):

This gives us both quality and accountability. We avoid the black-box problem by structuring decisions into auditable phases and exposing meaningful explanations.

9) Lean AI That Actually Ships

- Conversational RAG is static-index based and Vercel-friendly.
- No mandatory vector DB or heavy orchestration for MVP.
- Retrieval + citations keep answers grounded in curated Aether content.
- Provider abstraction supports free-first and future hosted models.

Presenter notes (50 sec):

We prioritized deployability and reliability over hype complexity. The architecture can scale up later, but it already delivers practical value with low operational burden.

10) Accessibility and Responsible UX

- Keyboard-friendly, readable, responsive interaction design.
- WCAG-aligned implementation direction.
- Clear copy boundaries: support tool, not therapy, not emergency care.
- Designed for low-cognitive-load moments.

Presenter notes (45 sec):

When users are overwhelmed, design debt becomes user harm. We treat clarity, readability, and predictable flows as safety features.

11) Closing: Why Aether Matters Now

Aether is a resilience operating layer for institutions that want:

- better early support,
- stronger privacy posture,
- safer peer connection,
- and measurable, governable AI.

The ask:

Pilot in one student population, measure outcomes, then scale modularly.

Presenter notes (35 sec):

Aether is ready for pragmatic pilots. The platform is already structured to learn responsibly: improve match quality, preserve trust, and keep human pathways visible.

Optional Appendix: 8-9 Minute Timing Plan

1. Slide 1: 0:35
2. Slide 2: 0:45
3. Slide 3: 0:55
4. Slide 4: 0:50
5. Slide 5: 1:00
6. Slide 6: 0:50
7. Slide 7: 0:50
8. Slide 8: 0:55
9. Slide 9: 0:50
10. Slide 10: 0:45
11. Slide 11: 0:35